



Strategic Punch

12 K-15 short range ballistic missiles with 1 ton nuclear warhead. Can hit targets 700 km away. (To be replaced by 3500 km 'K-X' SLBM in future.)

INS ARIHANT

COST: Rs 3,200 crore

Speed

22 knots dived
25 knots surfaced

Propulsion

1 pressurised water nuclear reactor
1 steam turbine 20,000 shp
7 bladed propeller

Displacement

5,000 tonnes

Dimensions

104 metres long
10 metres wide

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

At around noon on July 20, history was created at a brightly-lit, completely enclosed dry dock called the Ship Building Centre in Visakhapatnam. As the waters from the harbour cascaded into the 15-metre deep dry dock, a long black shape sitting on a series of wooden blocks, stirred. With a lurch, it slowly rose, just like a sea monster. After 11 years of construction,

the *Arihant* (meaning destroyer of enemies), India's first indigenous nuclear-powered submarine, was finally in the water. The three-hour 'test undocking' was only the dress rehearsal. The actual July 26 event will see Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's wife Gursharan Kaur breaking the auspicious coconut on the hull of the 5,000-tonne submarine, following the naval tradition where a lady launches a warship.

The momentous launch would complete a cycle which began in 1974

with the then prime minister Indira Gandhi authorising the building of a nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine (SSBN) under the classified Advanced Technology Vessel (ATV) project. For over three decades, the highly classified programme has been propelled by political vigour. Carried out under the direct supervision of successive prime ministers, it formed part of the national secrets, including the nuclear weapons programme, which each incumbent bequeathed to his suc-